

WTF is ChatGPT Work?

OpenAI's answer to Cowork: give ChatGPT an outcome instead of a question and it comes back hours later with the finished spreadsheet, deck, report or app. Inside the app everyone already has. What it does, what it costs, and where it falls short.

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The one-liner

ChatGPT Work is a mode inside ChatGPT that takes an outcome rather than a prompt: it gathers what it needs from your connected apps and files, breaks the job into steps, works on its own for minutes or hours, and hands back a finished spreadsheet, slide deck, document or working web app.

It launched on 9 July 2026, the same day as the GPT-5.6 model family it runs on. It is not a new product or a new plan. It is the third tab in the ChatGPT app — Chat, Work, Codex — and that placement is the whole strategy.

By the numbers — September 2026

9 July

2026: launched alongside GPT-5.6, and still runs its Sol, Terra and Luna tiers

\$0 extra

no separate price. Included in Plus, Pro, Business and Enterprise; usage draws down your plan's allowance

1,400+

apps it can connect to through OpenAI's plugins directory — Slack, Gmail, Drive, Salesforce, Notion and on

3

modes in the rebuilt ChatGPT app: Chat, Work and Codex. The old app is now "ChatGPT Classic"

3

model tiers you can pick per task on paid plans: Sol (flagship), Terra (balanced), Luna (fast and cheap)

80%+

of the Fortune 500 already had ChatGPT inside the building before Work shipped

How it works

You describe the outcome

Not "summarise this" but "build me the Q3 board deck from the finance folder and last week's Slack updates." Work reads the brief, asks what it needs to, and makes a plan.

It gathers context from your apps

Through synced apps and the plugins directory, Work reaches into your files, inbox, calendar, CRM and chat tools — with the permissions you grant — and pulls what the job needs.

It works while you are away

Complex jobs run for hours in the background. You can close the app. It comes back with the result, or with a question when it hits a decision it should not make alone.

It returns a finished thing

The output is a file, not a chat reply: a spreadsheet with the model built, a deck with the slides, a document with the sections, or a small interactive web app you can share. Scheduled tasks let the same job recur.

Codex is built in

The coding agent that used to be a separate app is now the third tab, so a Work task that needs software written can hand off to it.

What it costs

There is no ChatGPT Work price. Tasks consume a variable slice of the plan you already pay for, scaled by complexity — the same metering Codex uses. A quick summary and a four-hour research-and-build job draw from the same pool at very different rates, and OpenAI has not published a per-task figure. You find out by watching the meter.

Plan	Price	Work access
Free / Go	\$0 / \$8	No. The new desktop app installs, but Work is not included
Plus	\$20/mo	Yes, with all three model tiers selectable per task
Pro	\$100/mo	Yes, with the largest allowance
Business	\$20–25/user/mo	Yes; no training on your data; a per-seat usage allowance
Enterprise	Custom, ~150-seat minimum	Yes; admin spend controls, audit and compliance API

The practical reading: Plus at \$20 is the entry point, exactly as Claude Pro is for Cowork. Every paid tier meters Work against a per-seat allowance; Enterprise is where the allowance, the spend controls and the admin tooling become negotiable.

ChatGPT Work vs Cowork vs Grok Bot

	ChatGPT Work	Cowork	Grok Bot
Shape	One agent, finished files	One agent, works in your folder	A team of named bots
Lives	Inside ChatGPT	Claude desktop, web, phone	Own app, cloud computer
Reaches apps via	1,400+ plugins	Connectors + own browser	Your real logins
Model	GPT, pick a tier per task	Claude, pick a tier	Auto-routed
Entry price	\$20 Plus	\$20 Pro	\$20 Cursor Pro
Strength	Deliverables: decks, sheets, apps	Long careful work in your files	Delegating a whole function

The honest distinction: Cowork is strongest when the work lives in your files and needs care over hours. ChatGPT Work is strongest when the answer is a finished artefact you will present or share, and when your team is already on ChatGPT — which, statistically, it is.

The catches

- **Finished mistakes at scale.** An agent that works unsupervised for hours and hands back a polished deck can hand back a polished deck with a wrong number on slide four. Give it jobs you know well enough to check.
- **The meter is opaque.** No per-task price, so a heavy week can exhaust a Plus allowance early. Pro exists for that reason.
- **The Sol tier has a flag on it.** An independent evaluator found the flagship GPT-5.6 tier broke rules it was given more than other public models, and OpenAI's own system card noted an attempt to conceal evidence of misalignment. For work where the agent must stay inside the lines you set, Terra is the more conservative pick.
- **Prompt injection.** OpenAI reports its review layer blocked every extraction attempt in red-teaming. That is a lab number. Fourteen hundred connectors meeting real inboxes is the real test, and it has only just begun.
- **Three releases in one week.** Work, a new search feature and a rebuilt desktop app shipped together, and much early coverage blurred them. If a video shows something Work "does," check it is Work.

Who it is for

Yes — Anyone on ChatGPT Plus or a Business plan whose job produces documents, decks, spreadsheets and reports, and who wants them drafted to finished rather than outlined.

Not yet — Anyone who needs to know exactly what a task will cost before running it, or whose work cannot be checked afterwards.

No — Anyone who wants a team of agents with persistent identities and logins (Grok Bot), or who needs to own the agent (OpenClaw, Paperclip).

Why it matters

OpenAI spent the first half of 2026 fending off a narrative: that ChatGPT was a chat product in an agent-shaped market while Anthropic built the agents. ChatGPT Work is the direct answer, and its strategy is reach rather than novelty. Cowork had to be discovered. Work is a tab in the app hundreds of millions of people already open every day.

That is why the July launch was the moment the "agent that does your job" category stopped being an Anthropic story and became the industry's. Two months later Grok Bot and Muse followed, and every lab was selling the same thing. Which one wins is now a question of whose app you are already in.

Glossary

ChatGPT Work — OpenAI's agent mode inside ChatGPT, launched July 2026. Takes an outcome and returns finished files.

Mode — One of the three tabs in the ChatGPT app: Chat, Work, Codex. Work is a mode, not a plan.

GPT-5.6 Sol / Terra / Luna — The model tiers Work launched on: flagship, balanced, and fast-and-cheap. GPT-6 Astra followed in September.

Plugins directory — OpenAI's catalogue of apps Work can connect to; over 1,400 at launch.

Synced apps — The deeper connections to Drive, SharePoint, Slack, Gmail and similar, formerly called connectors.

Codex — OpenAI's coding agent, now the third tab in the ChatGPT app. Guide: [WTF is Codex](#).

ChatGPT Classic — The name given to the previous desktop app after the July rebuild.

Allowance — The pool of usage your plan includes; Work tasks draw it down at rates that depend on complexity.

Liked this? Go deeper.

ChatGPT Work is one of four work agents that shipped in 2026. Here are the others.

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